MIDNIGHTWEBS · FREE RESOURCE

AI Search Visibility Checklist

AI Overviews, AI Mode, ChatGPT Search and Perplexity now answer questions before people click. This checklist shows how to make your pages eligible, quotable and measurable in AI search without chasing shortcuts that do not work.

• Updated November 2026 • 13 min read • PDF

1. Understand what actually changed

AI search is still search. Google says AI Overviews and AI Mode use the same crawling, indexing and ranking foundations as regular Search, and there is no special file or schema that unlocks them. "AEO" and "GEO" are useful labels for the work, not separate ranking systems.

- [ ] Accept that being indexed and eligible for a snippet is the entry ticket; nothing else compensates for a page Google cannot crawl.
- [ ] Keep the fundamentals: crawlable HTML, internal links, canonical URLs, correct status codes and a clean XML sitemap.
- [ ] Decide whether your site is opted in to Search generative AI features in Search Console; this is a visibility control, not a ranking signal.
- [ ] Treat `llms.txt` as optional agent housekeeping. Google says it ignores the file; some non-Google tools may read it.
- [ ] Do not mass-produce pages for every phrasing of a question. Google treats scaled content abuse as spam and it rarely earns citations.

> **Short version:** optimize for people and for being quoted. The technical work is ordinary SEO done consistently.

2. Make the page easy to retrieve

AI answers are assembled from sources that can be fetched and understood. Remove the small technical blockers that quietly exclude good pages.

- [ ] Confirm the page is indexed and can show a snippet; check Search Console page indexing and manual actions.
- [ ] Allow Googlebot and Bingbot in `robots.txt`, and check that your CDN, firewall or bot protection is not blocking them.
- [ ] Serve the main answer in HTML. If content only appears after a click, login or client-side interaction, assume it may be missed.
- [ ] Use one clear H1 and descriptive H2/H3 headings that match the questions people ask.
- [ ] Keep important pages a few internal links from the homepage, and link related pages with meaningful anchor text.
- [ ] Fix redirect chains, broken links, duplicate URLs and accidental `noindex` before rewriting content.

3. Write answers that are easy to extract

Clear writing is not a trick, but it does make a page easier to quote. Start each section with the answer, then support it with detail.

- [ ] Open each section with a direct one- or two-sentence answer before adding context.
- [ ] Use question-shaped headings where they match real searches, and answer the question in the first paragraph.

- [ ] Keep paragraphs to two to four sentences and use lists, tables or numbered steps for comparisons and processes.
- [ ] Define terms explicitly and state the conditions: who it applies to, what it costs, what can go wrong.
- [ ] Cover the dimensions people compare: price, timeline, requirements, risks, alternatives and results.
- [ ] Do not stuff keywords or rewrite for bots. Google says its systems understand synonyms and general meaning.

4. Add evidence, experience and a named author

Generic summaries are everywhere. Pages that show first-hand work, specific numbers and real accountability are harder to replace with a generic answer.

- [ ] Include original data, screenshots, test results, prices, timelines or before-and-after examples from your own work.
- [ ] Add a real author byline with relevant credentials and a link to an author or team page.
- [ ] Show a visible published date and a meaningful updated date; update the content when facts change.
- [ ] Cite primary sources such as Google documentation, W3C standards or regulators, and link to the exact page.
- [ ] Avoid invented expert quotes, fake reviews and purchased mentions; they are a short-term tactic with long-term risk.
- [ ] Use high-quality images and video where they help, with alt text, captions and transcripts.

5. Make your business easy to identify

AI systems need to connect a page, a brand and a set of facts. Inconsistent details create doubt; consistent details build confidence.

- [ ] Add Organization schema with your legal name, logo, URL, contact details and `sameAs` links to authoritative profiles.
- [ ] Keep your name, address, phone, services and hours identical on your site, Google Business Profile and major directories.
- [ ] Use Article schema with author, `datePublished`, `dateModified` and publisher for every guide.
- [ ] Add LocalBusiness, Service or Product schema where it matches the page, and keep prices and availability current.
- [ ] Only mark up FAQs, reviews or ratings that are visibly present on the page.
- [ ] Make the About and Contact pages specific: who you are, where you work, how to reach a human.

6. Keep the technical basics strong

AI features inherit the same page experience and technical signals as Search. A fast, stable, well-structured page is easier to retrieve and easier to trust.

- [ ] Pre-render or server-render important content; do not hide the answer behind tabs, accordions loaded by script, or a login.
- [ ] Use semantic HTML and native elements before ARIA; make sure headings, lists and tables describe the content.
- [ ] Meet Core Web Vitals on mobile, especially LCP and INP, and test on a mid-range phone.
- [ ] Keep HTTPS, valid canonicals and one preferred URL per topic; avoid near-duplicate pages.
- [ ] Check that structured data matches the visible text and passes a validator.

- [x] Submit an XML sitemap and monitor crawl, indexing and security issues in Search Console.

7. Measure visibility in AI surfaces

AI traffic is often undercounted because answers appear without a click. Measure citations and assisted outcomes, not just last-click sessions.

- [x] Build a prompt panel of 10 to 20 real buying questions and check them across Google AI Overviews/AI Mode, ChatGPT Search, Perplexity and Copilot.
- [x] Record whether you are cited, which URL is cited and which competitors appear; repeat the same prompts monthly.
- [x] Segment referrals from AI domains in analytics, and accept that many AI-assisted visits will be reported as direct or branded search.
- [x] Track assisted conversions and branded search demand alongside clicks and impressions.
- [x] When a competitor is cited instead of you, look for missing evidence, unclear answers or a weak entity signal on your page.
- [x] Refresh the pages that already rank well before creating new ones; existing authority is easier to build on.

8. A 30-day action plan

You do not need a new department. Fix the blockers first, improve the pages that already have demand, then measure what changed.

- [x] Week 1: audit indexing, robots.txt, canonicals, sitemaps and the Search Console generative AI setting.
- [x] Week 2: rewrite the five pages that bring the most revenue with direct answers, evidence and clear headings.

- [ ] Week 3: add author details, Organization/Article schema and consistent business facts across profiles.
- [ ] Week 4: publish one piece of original research, set up a monthly prompt panel and fix the weakest cited competitor gap.

> **What not to do:** buying mentions, publishing hundreds of thin pages, or adding an `llms.txt` file and assuming Google will reward it. None of these replace useful content and a crawlable site.

Sources and further reading

Guidance in this checklist was checked against the following primary and industry sources in November 2026.

- [ ] Google Search Central: Optimizing for generative AI features
- [ ] Google Search Central: AI features and your website
- [ ] Search Console: Search generative AI control
- [ ] Search Engine Land: AI Overviews optimization guide
- [ ] Sanity: AEO and GEO for developers
- [ ] SearchScore: Technical GEO